



MA

A WORD

Ma

Look at the character. A gate — 門 — with the sun showing through the gap in it. *Ma* is that gap: the interval, the pause, the space between. In Japanese thought it is not emptiness as lack but emptiness as substance — the silence that makes the music, the rest between two notes, the bare stretch of wall that lets the one print speak.

A Western eye sees an empty corner and wants to furnish it. The trained eye sees *ma* — a deliberate interval, doing work. In summer, when the heat tempts you to add fans, throws, cooling clutter, *ma* is the discipline that says: the open space is the

"The gap is not where the design stops. It is where the design happens."

